Modal Verbs

Name: _____ Date: _____ Year 6 English — Grammar

ACARA v9.0: AC9E6LA08

Learning Intention

I am learning how modal verbs show different levels of certainty, possibility and obligation in a sentence.

Success Criteria

- I can identify a modal verb in a sentence.
- I can sort modal verbs by certainty, possibility or obligation.
- I can choose the right modal verb to change the meaning of a sentence.

How Sure Are You?

Modal verbs show how certain, possible or necessary something is: 'will/shall' (certainty), 'may/might/could' (possibility), 'must/have to' (obligation).

Worked Example

It might rain. (possibility)
It will rain. (certainty)
You must bring a raincoat. (obligation)

Part A — Warm Up

Circle the modal verb: **walked might quickly**

True or False: 'must' shows possibility, not obligation. _____

Write a modal verb that shows strong certainty. _____

Part B — Core Skills

Sort into Certainty, Possibility or Obligation: *will, might, must, could, shall, have to*

Group / Column 1	Group / Column 2

Rewrite to show less certainty: *It will snow tomorrow.*

_____

Rewrite to show obligation: *Students bring a hat to school.*

_____

Explain how changing 'may' to 'must' changes the meaning of a sentence.

_____

Modal Verb Bank

will • shall • may • might • could • can • must • have to • should

Working Space — Write 3 Sentences Using 3 Different Modal Verbs

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Part C — Challenge: The School Excursion Notice

> *A Year 6 teacher wrote a notice: "Students must wear closed shoes. It might be muddy, so you could bring spare socks. We will leave at 9am sharp."*

Q8. Identify the 4 modal verbs in the notice and classify each as certainty, possibility or obligation.

Q9. Explain why the teacher used 'must' instead of 'could' for the closed shoes instruction.

Q10. Rewrite the notice changing 'must' to 'might' for the shoes instruction. Explain how this changes the meaning for students reading it.

Answer Key — Part A

A1: might

A2: False — 'must' usually shows obligation (necessity), not possibility.

A3: will (accept 'shall').

Answer Key — Part B

B1: Certainty: will, shall. Possibility: might, could. Obligation: must, have to.

B2: It might snow tomorrow (accept 'could snow').

B3: Students must bring a hat to school (accept 'have to bring').

B4: 'May' suggests something is only possible or allowed, while 'must' shows it is necessary or required — changing a soft suggestion into a strict rule.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: must = obligation; might and could = possibility; will = certainty.

C9: The teacher used 'must' to make it clear that wearing closed shoes is a required safety rule, not just an optional suggestion.

C10: "Students might wear closed shoes." This changes a strict, required rule into an optional suggestion, which could be confusing or unsafe if students choose not to follow it.

I Can Checklist

- ☐ I can identify modal verbs.
- ☐ I can sort modal verbs by meaning.
- ☐ I can choose modal verbs to change meaning precisely.

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